

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Six

Religious Dominance

The system that ranks one faith above all others
A Fundamental Matrix

Religious Dominance is the system that ranks adherents of one religion above others, enforces religious conformity, and extracts loyalty, financial contribution, and political allegiance. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the compound to the Sharia penal code to the slow death of the doubter who cannot leave without losing community.

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CHAPTER 6 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Religious Dominance

Religious Dominance covers two related operations. The first is **inter-religious dominance** — the ranking of one religion above others (Christian vs Muslim vs traditionalist vs atheist in the Nigerian context). The second is **intra-religious sectarianism** — the ranking of one branch above another within a religion (Sunni vs Shia, Catholic vs Pentecostal, Ahmadiyya vs mainstream).

The framework's own note (Chapter 1) is that religion is not inherently oppressive but functions as a willing amplifier and legitimacy supplier for other oppressive systems. This chapter studies Religious Dominance as a matrix in its own right, separating the religious-identity logic from its Canon-supplying function for other matrices. The Canon-supply function returns when each later matrix describes religion as a contributor to its own ascension ritual.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 5. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Religious Dominance and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Religious Dominance Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Religious Dominance is the system that ranks adherents of one religion above others, enforces religious conformity, and extracts loyalty, financial contribution, and political allegiance from adherents. The theoretical foundations draw on Talal Asad's *Genealogies of Religion* (1993), which argues that 'religion' as a universal category is itself a Christian Western construction imposed on other traditions.

The Nigerian context is central. The country is roughly split between a Muslim-majority North and a Christian-majority South, with traditional religion surviving across both regions and atheists invisible in public life. Mahmood Mamdani's *Good Muslim, Bad Muslim* (2004) shows how colonial administration treated the North as Muslim and the South as Christian for administrative convenience, freezing a more fluid pre-colonial reality.

Lamin Sanneh's *West African Christianity* (1983) and Matthew Hassan Kukah's *Religion, Politics and Power in Northern Nigeria* (1993) document the colonial and post-colonial religious settlement. Ruth Marshall's *Political Spiritualities* (2009) and Ebenezer Obadare's *Pentecostal Republic* (2018) trace the rise of Pentecostalism in the South from the 1970s. Saba Mahmood's *Politics of Piety* (2005), though written about Egypt, supplies the analytical vocabulary for how pious practice produces the subject.

1.1 What Religious Dominance Extracts

Religious Dominance extracts five things. First, **tithes, zakat, and offerings**: the financial contributions that adherents owe the religious institution. The tithe in Pentecostal churches (10% of income), the zakat in Islam (2.5% of wealth), the harvest thanksgiving in mainline churches, the sadaqah in Muslim practice.

Second, **devotional labour**: the time spent in services, prayers, fasting, festivals, and religious instruction. The five daily prayers in Islam (which together take 30-60 minutes minimum). The Sunday three-hour service in many Pentecostal churches. The Ramadan fast from dawn to dusk for 29-30 days. The Lenten fast. The weekly fellowship meeting.

Third, **political allegiance**: the bloc vote, the religious leader's endorsement, the mobilisation of the faithful for a candidate or policy. Fourth, **obedience to clergy**: the deference labour performed toward religious leaders, who are treated as having authority over adherents' personal decisions. Fifth, **reproductive capacity for the faith community**: the production of children raised in the faith, ensuring the community's demographic continuation.

1.2 What Religious Dominance Enforces

Religious Dominance enforces five standards. First, the **religious identity standard**: every person must belong to a recognised religion. The atheist is deviant. The traditionalist is backward. The syncretist is suspect. The ‘nothing in particular’ respondent to religious-identity surveys is treated as failing.

Second, the **religious practice standard**: adherents must attend services, observe fasts, perform rituals, and participate in festivals. The Christian who does not attend church is ‘backslidden.’ The Muslim who does not pray is ‘nominal.’ The traditionalist who does not perform the annual festival is ‘lapsed.’

Third, the **religious purity standard**: adherents must not convert out, must not marry outside (in some communities), must not blaspheme, must not criticise the religion publicly. Fourth, the **religious authority standard**: adherents must defer to religious leaders on personal and communal matters. Fifth, the **religious law in personal matters standard**: marriage, divorce, inheritance, and child custody are governed by religious law in many contexts.

1.3 What Options Religious Dominance Removes

Concretely, Religious Dominance removes the option of apostasy. The convert from Islam to Christianity (or vice versa) is shunned by family, sometimes killed. Mubarak Bala, the Nigerian humanist atheist, was sentenced to 24 years’ imprisonment in April 2022 for blasphemy after renouncing Islam publicly. The sentence is the structural enforcement of the religious purity standard.

It removes the option of atheism. The atheist Nigerian is treated as immoral, incompetent, and untrustworthy. The 1999 Constitution requires the oath of office to be sworn on a holy book (Quran or Bible), with no secular alternative. The atheist who refuses to swear on a holy book is barred from public office.

It removes the option of conversion. The Christian who converts to Islam in the North may be killed by family. The Muslim who converts to Christianity in the South may be killed by family. The traditionalist who converts to either Christianity or Islam loses access to the shrines and the lineage rituals that have organised their community for centuries.

It removes the option of syncretism — the practice of combining elements from multiple religions. The Yoruba who attends church on Sunday and consults the Ifa priest on Monday is treated as ‘not really Christian’ or ‘not really Muslim’ by the institutions of both. It removes the option of blasphemy — public criticism of religion. It removes the option of interfaith marriage without conversion. It removes the option of religious exemption from public services that violate one’s conscience. Each removal is enforced by law, by family, and by the triads below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains five enforcement triads and five extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Religious Identity Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject belong to a recognised religion. A parent, a religious leader, a neighbour, an employer, or a stranger could fill this role. The enforcement is performed by asking ‘are you saved?’, by treating the non-religious as suspicious, by refusing to do business with the non-believer, or by punishing open atheism.

The subject conforms by claiming a religious identity, by attending services enough to be recognised, or by hiding their non-belief. The conforming act is the claimed identity itself — the subject becomes ‘Christian’ or ‘Muslim’ on the form, in the introduction, in the social performance.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The atheist who refuses to claim a religious identity loses the option to employment in many workplaces, the option to political office (because of the holy-book oath requirement), and the option to social acceptance. The traditionalist who claims their actual identity loses the option to respect from Christians and Muslims who treat traditional religion as backward.

The witness is the person who hears the religious identity demand and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by claiming their own religious identity prominently. The witness’s complicity normalises the demand.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Religious Practice Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the adherent perform prescribed religious practices. The parent who demands the child attend Sunday school. The Imam who demands the congregant pray five times daily. The pastor who demands the member tithe and attend midweek service. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by tracking attendance, by publicly noting absence, or by punishing non-compliance.

The subject conforms by performing. The Christian attends church on Sunday. The Muslim prays five times daily and attends Friday Jumu’ah. The traditionalist performs the annual festival. The conforming act is the performance itself — the body in the place of worship, the head bowed, the mouth moving in the prescribed words.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adherent who would rather rest on Sunday loses the option to rest, which is to say, loses the option to bodily recovery from the work week. The Muslim worker who would rather not wake at 5am for Fajr prayer loses the option to sleep, which is to say, loses the option to cognitive function the next day. The adherent who would rather not fast loses the option to food and water during daylight hours for a month.

The witness is the person who watches the practice enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves perform the prescribed practices and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who benefits from the adherent's piety — the parent whose status rises because the child is recognised as pious — without personally commanding the practice.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: Religious Purity Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the adherent remain within the religious boundary. The parent who demands the child not convert. The community elder who demands the adherent not marry outside the faith. The religious leader who demands the adherent not criticise the religion publicly. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by shunning, by disownment, or by violence.

The subject conforms by remaining within the boundary. The conforming act is the refusal to convert, the refusal to marry outside, the refusal to criticise. The conformity is the absence of action — the subject does not do the prohibited thing.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The convert who would rather change religion loses the option to family support, sometimes to physical safety. The adherent who would rather marry outside the faith loses the option to family approval of the marriage. The adherent who would rather criticise the religion loses the option to public speech, sometimes to life — Deborah Samuel was killed in Sokoto in May 2022 for a WhatsApp message her classmates deemed blasphemous.

The witness is the person who watches the purity enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves model compliance by remaining within the boundary. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that the boundary is necessary.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: Religious Authority Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the adherent defer to religious leaders on personal and communal matters. The pastor who demands the member consult him before marriage. The Imam who demands the congregant seek his ruling on a family dispute. The parent who demands the child obey the Sunday school teacher. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by signalling disapproval of independent decision-making, or by punishing those who decide without clerical approval.

The subject conforms by deferring. The conforming act is the consultation itself — the adherent approaches the religious leader, asks the question, accepts the ruling. The consultation is the proof of the system.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adherent who would rather decide independently loses the option to community approval of the decision, which is to say, loses the option to social standing. The woman who would rather not consult the pastor about her marriage loses the option to religious sanction for divorce, which is to say, loses the option to community support for leaving an abusive husband.

The witness is the person who watches the authority enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves defer to religious leaders and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose status rises because the adherent is recognised as obedient — the parent whose child is the pastor's favourite — without personally commanding the deference.

3.5 Enforcement Triad: Religious Law in Personal Matters Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the adherent's marriage, divorce, inheritance, and child custody be governed by religious law. The Imam who refuses to conduct a marriage without religious law applying. The pastor who demands the couple marry 'in the church' rather than at the registry. The family elder who demands the inheritance be distributed according to religious law. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by refusing recognition to alternative arrangements, or by punishing non-compliance.

The subject conforms by submitting their personal matters to religious law. The conforming act is the submission itself — the marriage conducted by the religious leader, the divorce granted by the religious court, the inheritance distributed by the religious formula. The submission is the proof of the system.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who would rather have her marriage governed by civil law loses the option to equal divorce rights, because religious law in many traditions gives the husband unilateral divorce. The daughter who would rather have her inheritance governed by civil law loses the option to equal inheritance, because religious law in many traditions gives the male heir a larger share. The mother who would rather have custody governed by civil law loses the option to custody in some religious traditions that grant custody to the father after a certain age.

The witness is the person who watches the religious-law enforcement and does not intervene, or who themselves submit their personal matters to religious law and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that personal matters are religious matters.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Tithes, Zakat, and Offerings

The extractor is the religious institution that requires financial contributions from adherents. The Pentecostal church that demands 10% of income as tithe. The mosque that collects zakat (2.5% of wealth) annually. The mainline church that collects harvest thanksgiving. The traditional shrine that collects festival dues. The extraction is performed by direct demand from the pulpit or minbar, by envelope-and-card tracking, by public naming of large donors, or by withholding community standing from non-contributors.

The subject conforms by giving. What is extracted is tangible: money, goods, labour. The extraction transfers resources from the subject to the religious institution. If nothing tangible transfers, it is not this triad.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adherent who gives 10% of income to the church loses the option to spend that money on food, school fees, or savings. The adherent who gives zakat loses the same. The extraction compounds with the family's other obligations — school fees for siblings, hospital bills for parents, festive contributions — and the cumulative loss is the option to economic security.

The witness is the person who watches the financial extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves give to their own religious institution. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who consumes the religious institution's services — the wedding conducted, the funeral conducted, the school place secured — without personally commanding the tithe.

This role is unstable. The moment the family member begins to demand contributions from other family members, they become extractors. Most adult family members drift into extraction over time, because the felt entitlement to religious contribution grows with each received service.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Devotional Labour

The extractor is the religious institution that requires the adherent's time. The five daily prayers in Islam. The Sunday three-hour service in Pentecostal churches. The Ramadan fast from dawn to dusk for a month. The Lenten fast. The weekly fellowship meeting. The midweek Bible study. The all-night vigil. The annual conference. The extraction is performed by direct command from the religious leader, by social pressure, or by punishing non-attendance.

The subject conforms by attending. What is extracted is the time itself — hours, days, sometimes weeks of the adherent's life, spent in prescribed religious activity. The extraction is silent. There is no envelope, no tribute. There is only the adherent's lost afternoon, lost week, lost year.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who spends 60 hours a week in religious activity loses the option to rest, which is to say, loses the option to bodily recovery. The student who spends the all-night vigil praying loses the option to sleep, which is to say, loses the option to cognitive function the next day. The mother who spends Sunday morning in church loses the option to be with her children, which is to say, loses the option to rest from the week's domestic labour.

The witness is the person who also attends, or who watches the attendance and says nothing. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the religious leader's family who consumes the devotional labour's fruits — the pastor's family lives in the church-provided house, the imam's family eats the food the congregation brought — without personally commanding the attendance.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Political Allegiance

The extractor is the religious leader or institution that requires the adherent's political allegiance. The pastor who endorses a candidate from the pulpit. The Imam who issues a fatwa on a political question. The religious association that mobilises the bloc vote. The extraction is performed by direct endorsement, by framing the political choice as religious duty, or by punishing those who vote against the religious bloc.

The subject conforms by voting as directed, by supporting the religious leader's political position, or by attending the political rally. The conforming act is the vote itself — the adherent's political agency is transferred to the religious leader.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The adherent who would rather vote on policy loses the option to vote according to their own judgment, which is to say, loses the option to democratic participation. The adherent who would rather not attend the political rally loses the option to community standing, which is to say, loses the option to social acceptance. The adherent who publicly dissents loses the option to physical safety, sometimes to life.

The witness is the person who watches the political extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves vote as directed. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the politician who wins the election because of the religious bloc vote — the politician benefits from the extraction without personally commanding it.

3.9 Extraction Triad: Obedience to Clergy

The extractor is the religious leader who requires the adherent's obedience. The pastor who demands the member consult him before major decisions. The Imam who demands the congregant follow his rulings. The Bablawo who demands the client perform the prescribed ritual. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by signalling disapproval of independent decision-making, or by punishing those who decide without clerical approval.

The subject conforms by obeying. What is extracted is the decision-making capacity — the adherent's judgment is transferred upward to the religious leader. The subject now decides not for themselves but according to the leader's ruling. The subject's mind has been annexed.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who consults the pastor about her marriage loses the option to decide independently, which is to say, loses the option to leave the marriage if the pastor rules against divorce. The employee who consults the Imam about a job offer loses the option to take the offer if the Imam rules against it. The student who consults the religious leader about a career choice loses the option to choose according to their own interests.

The witness is the person who watches the obedience extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves obey their own religious leader. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the religious leader's family and entourage who benefit from the deference — the pastor's wife who is greeted with extra respect, the Imam's son who is treated as a young scholar — without personally commanding the obedience.

3.10 Extraction Triad: Reproductive Capacity for the Faith Community

The extractor is the religious institution that requires the adherent to produce children raised in the faith. The pastor who preaches against childlessness. The Imam who preaches that the Muslim community must outbreed the Christian community. The family elder who demands the lineage continue. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by punishing childlessness, by forbidding contraception, or by forbidding abortion.

The subject conforms by reproducing. What is extracted is the reproductive capacity itself — the body's ability to produce a faith-community member, the years of fertility spent in pregnancy and childrearing, the physical and emotional cost of reproduction. The extraction is performed through the body.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The woman who is required to produce children for the faith community loses the option to a body that is not repeatedly pregnant, which is to say, loses the option to health, to career, to life. The couple who would rather not have children loses the option to refuse without social punishment. The woman who needs contraception loses the option to access it through religious hospitals that refuse to provide it.

The witness is the person who watches the reproductive extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the reproduction for the same faith community. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the religious leader whose congregation grows because of the adherent's reproduction — the pastor whose church membership rises, the Imam whose congregation expands — without personally commanding the reproduction.

Nascent forms of this system include: 'You must be saved', 'Are you born again?', 'Have you accepted Christ?', Praying loudly in public, Judging non-attenders, 'You are backslidden', 'Infidel', 'Kafir', 'Unbeliever', 'Sinner', Treating atheists as immoral, Refusing to eat with people of other faiths, Religious dress policing (hijab pressure), Religious dress policing (suit-and-tie at church), Religious food policing (fasting pressure), Judging women who don't cover, Judging men without beards, Calling people 'worldly', 'Pray about it', 'It is well', Religious test for friendship, Religious test for marriage, Religious test for business, 'Our daughter married a Muslim/Christian', Threatening apostates with hell, Threatening children with hell, 'You will go to hell if...', Disowning converts, Religious bullying in school, Judgmental silence at the backslider, Religious gossip about someone's piety, Pressuring colleagues to attend your church, Pressuring subordinates to convert, Weaponised prayer against enemies, Demonising mental illness, Demonising disability.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the ten triads above link into networks, Religious Dominance scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian religious institution.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. Religious Dominance spreads through this form in every Nigerian religious institution.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest religious authority in the hierarchy enforces on the layer below. The peak enforcer has no human above-them in this hierarchy, so the enforcement is the purest expression of religious authority at the top. The peak extracts tithes, devotional labour, political allegiance, obedience, and reproductive capacity from the layer below.

In the Pentecostal megachurch, the peak triad is the General Overseer enforcing on Provincial Pastors. In the Catholic Church, the peak is the Pope enforcing on Cardinals (with the Pope's authority extending through the Vatican to Nigerian bishops). In the Sunni mosque network, the peak is the Sultan of Sokoto enforcing on Emirs and State Chief Imams. In the Shia network, the peak is the regional Marja enforcing on local Sheikhs. In the traditional Yoruba religion, the peak is the Ooni of Ife as custodian of the Ifa corpus.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain's character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The Provincial Pastor who kneels for the General Overseer in the morning demands kneeling from Area Pastors in the afternoon. The State Chief Imam who defers to the Sultan on Friday demands deference from the local Imam on Saturday.

The middle is where Religious Dominance reproduces. The subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow — as a pastor, an imam, a deacon, a youth leader. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the adherent becomes a religious leader, they have been disciplined by Religious Dominance for decades.

In the Pentecostal megachurch, the middle nodes run from General Overseer down through Provincial Pastor, Area Pastor, Parish Pastor, Deacon, Worker, and Member. Each layer enforces religious identity, practice, purity, authority, and law on the layer below, and is in turn enforced on by the layer above. The Catholic, Sunni, Shia, and traditional hierarchies have analogous structures.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked religious enforcer enforces on the ordinary adherent. The Parish Pastor enforcing on the Member. The local Imam enforcing on the congregant. The Sunday school teacher enforcing on the child. The youth leader enforcing on the youth member. The bottom is where the system's violence is most concentrated.

The bottom node is also where the hierarchy meets the community form. The Parish Pastor who enforces on the Member is simultaneously the enforcer in a hierarchy (above the member) and the subject in the same hierarchy (below the Area Pastor). The parish is a node in two directions: the Pastor extracts obedience from the Member what the Area Pastor extracts from the Pastor.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one religious triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. Religious Dominance spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed religious enforcement without dissenting.

CAN and SCIA Networks

The Christian Association of Nigeria (CAN) and the Supreme Council for Islamic Affairs (SCIA) are the two largest religious community networks. CAN organises the Christian bloc across Catholic, Protestant, and Pentecostal divisions. SCIA organises the Muslim bloc across Sunni, Sufi, and (controversially) Shia divisions. Both networks circulate enforcement patterns across thousands of congregations without any single religious leader issuing a command.

Religious Media

Religious media amplifies the community form. The Pentecostal television channel broadcasts the General Overseer's sermon to millions of households, circulating the religious practice and authority triads across the viewing audience. The Islamic radio station broadcasts the Imam's tafsir to millions of listeners, circulating the same triads. Social media amplifies further — the WhatsApp voice note from the Sheikh, the Facebook Live from the Pastor, the Twitter thread from the youth leader.

Religious Schools

Religious schools circulate Religious Dominance across generations. The Sunday school in the church, the Islamiyya and Quranic school in the mosque, the catechism class in the Catholic parish, the Babalawo's apprenticeship in the traditional religion. Each is a community in which the next generation is taught the religious identity, practice, purity, authority, and law standards. The teaching is enforced by the children themselves on each other.

Religious Fellowships on Campus

The religious fellowships on Nigerian university campuses — NIFES and FCS for Christians, MSSN for Muslims, the Catholic Charismatic Renewal, the Anglican Fellowship — are textbook Religious Dominance communities. The fellowship circulates the religious practice and purity triads across the

student body, enforces the religious identity standard through pressure to join, and polices the religious purity standard through monitoring of dating, dress, and speech.

The Religious Riot as Community Enforcement

The most violent form of Religious Dominance community is the religious riot. The Miss World riots of November 2002 in Kaduna killed over 200 people after a journalist was deemed to have insulted the Prophet. The 2006 cartoon riots across northern Nigeria killed over 100 people after the Danish Jyllands-Posten publication. The 2011 post-election violence in Kaduna and Zaria killed over 800 people along religious-ethnic lines.

The Deborah Samuel lynching of May 2022 in Sokoto was a community enforcement event. Deborah, a Christian student at Shehu Shagari College of Education, sent a WhatsApp voice note that her Muslim classmates deemed blasphemous. She was beaten, stoned, and burnt by a mob of her classmates. The Bridget Agbahome killing of June 2016 in Kano was another: a Christian trader was killed by a mob at Kofar Wambai market after being accused of blasphemy. Both were community enforcement of the religious purity standard, performed by ordinary citizens acting as the witness-become-enforcer.

The framework treats these events as analytically legible: they are the community form of Religious Dominance doing what communities do when the witness stops being complicit and becomes the enforcer. The riot is the triad scaled to a mob.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Religious Dominance triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Religious Dominance leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Religious Dominance simultaneously.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Religious Dominance's bureaucracy is the codified religious-identity structure. The 1999 Constitution prohibits a state religion (Section 10) while preserving Sharia courts in the North and customary courts across the country. The Sharia Penal Code Law of Zamfara State 2000, replicated in 11 other northern states, codified religious law as state criminal law — including amputation for theft, flogging for fornication, and stoning for adultery (though the latter has not been carried out).

The Criminal Code Act 1916 (applicable in the South) and the Penal Code (applicable in the North) both codify blasphemy as a criminal offence. Criminal Code Section 204 provides for up to two years' imprisonment for an insult to religion. Penal Code Section 382 provides for up to two years' imprisonment for uttering words with intent to wound religious feelings. Mubarak Bala was sentenced under the Penal Code in April 2022 to 24 years' imprisonment for blasphemy.

The Pilgrimage Boards are federal bureaucracy. The Nigerian Christian Pilgrim Commission (NCPC) organises Christian pilgrimage to Jerusalem, with federal and state government subsidies. The National Hajj Commission of Nigeria (NAHCON) organises Muslim pilgrimage to Mecca, with similar subsidies. Both are funded by taxpayer money, including from citizens of other faiths and none. The original constitutional authors are dead or retired. The bureaucracy lives.

Religious instruction in public schools is codified. Christian Religious Knowledge (CRK) and Islamic Religious Knowledge (IRK) are offered as subjects in primary and secondary schools, with students tracked by their family's religion. Religious holidays are codified in the Public Holidays Act — Christmas, Easter, Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha, Eid al-Maulud. The religious tax-exemption status for religious organisations is codified in the Companies and Allied Matters Act (CAMA). The Kaduna State Religious Preaching Regulation Edict 1984 (still technically in force) requires preachers to be licensed by the state.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Religious Dominance's stratification is the daily experience of religious rank in every institutional encounter. **Christian and Muslim as recognised** — the two religions are treated as the legitimate religious options, with the Presidency traditionally alternating between a Christian from the South and a Muslim from the North. **Traditionalist as marginalised** — the adherent of traditional religion is treated as backward and is excluded from the religious-identity categories on official forms.

Atheist as criminalised — the atheist is outside the legal horizon, with blasphemy laws applicable to public atheist speech and the holy-book oath requirement barring atheists from public office. **Sunni vs Shia** — Shia Muslims are a minoritised community in northern Nigeria, with the Islamic Movement in Nigeria (IMN) subjected to state violence (the Zaria massacre of December 2015 killed over 300 IMN members).

Catholic vs Pentecostal — Catholicism was historically dominant in southern Christianity, with Pentecostalism rising from the 1970s to displace it. Pentecostalism is now dominant in southern public life, with Catholicism treated as 'orthodox' and somewhat behind. **Ahmadiyya as persecuted minority** — the Ahmadiyya community is treated as non-Muslim by mainstream Sunni authorities and is subjected to discrimination within the Muslim community.

Clergy vs laity — the religious leader ranks above the adherent in moral authority, decision-making, and social standing. **Believer vs doubter** — the believer ranks above the doubter in community standing. **Saved vs lost** — in evangelical Christian framing, the saved rank above the lost in eternal destination and therefore in present moral standing. The ranking is in the air; it does not need to be announced.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Religious Dominance's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into religious categories. **Believer** and **unbeliever** — the universal pair, with believer as the default and unbeliever as the deviant. **Faithful** and **backslider** — the moral pair, with faithful as the default and backslider as the fallen.

Saved and **lost** — the evangelical Christian pair, with saved as the elect and lost as the damned. **Sunni** and **Shia** — the Islamic pair, with Sunni as the majority and Shia as the minoritised. **Catholic, Pentecostal, Anglican, Methodist, Baptist** — the Christian subdivisions, with Catholic as 'orthodox' and Pentecostal as 'spirit-filled.'

Sufi and **Salafi** — the Islamic subdivisions, with Sufi as 'traditional' and Salafi as 'reformist.'

Orthodox and **heterodox** — the moral pair, with orthodox as the legitimate and heterodox as the deviation. **Faithful** and **heretic** — the policing pair, with faithful as the conforming and heretic as the condemned.

The classification does the work before any individual enforcer shows up. A person walking into a job interview in northern Nigeria is already classified; the interviewer may ask the candidate's religion

directly or indirectly (through state of origin, through name, through secondary school). A person walking into a rental interview in southern Nigeria is already classified; the landlord may refuse to rent to a Muslim tenant because ‘the area is Christian.’ Classification is the most universal structural residue.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Religious Dominance ascended? Yes on all three counts. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society without religious identity as a primary social category — despite the fact that pre-colonial Nigerian religion was more flexible, and the fact that the current arrangement was installed by specific colonial and post-colonial legal instruments within living memory.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that the religious-identity structure has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the colonial codification, the Sharia courts, the Pilgrimage Boards, the blasphemy laws — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes the religious-identity structure as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? Pre-colonial Nigerian religion was syncretic and flexible. The Yoruba Orisa tradition had no missionaries, no canon, no centralised authority. The Igbo spiritual system was lineage-based, with each compound maintaining its own deities and rituals. The Hausa city-states had a mix of indigenous Hausa religion and Islam, with the Maguzawa (Hausa traditionalists) living alongside Muslims without category crisis.

Islam arrived in West Africa through trans-Saharan trade from the 11th century, but the Sokoto Jihad of 1804 was a recent political-theological event that imposed a stricter Islamic identity on the Hausa states. Christianity arrived with the colonial missions in the 1840s (CMS in Badagry, Catholic missions in Lagos and Onitsha) and was imposed through the school system. Both religions arrived as invasions of older arrangements, not as natural developments.

Also forgotten: the colonial state managed religion through Indirect Rule, using religious identity as an administrative category. The colonial administration treated the North as Muslim and the South as Christian for administrative convenience, freezing a more fluid pre-colonial reality. The 1979 and 1999 Constitutions' 'multi-religious state' framing was a deliberate compromise, not a natural arrangement. The 1987 OIC (Organisation of Islamic Conference) membership controversy and the 1999-2002 Sharia implementation debate were continuations of the colonial settlement, not innovations.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Religious Dominance produces Stratification. The clergy's felt entitlement to tithes, deference, and obedience is now natural, automatic, unquestionable.

The General Overseer who expects the Provincial Pastors to wait for his entrance does not experience this as a demand. He experiences it as the natural order. The Imam who expects the congregants to follow his rulings does not feel he is enforcing. He feels he is being accorded his due.

The religious majority's entitlement to social default is also natural. The Sunni Muslim in the North does not experience their religious recognition as privilege. They experience it as the way things are. The Pentecostal Christian in the South does not experience their religious recognition as privilege either. Both treat their religious majority status as natural, and treat the religious minority's complaints as 'troublemaking.'

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the congregant did not stand when the General Overseer entered, the Overseer felt surprise. The hundredth time, the Overseer feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the religious enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The father who beats the child for 'questioning God' gains nothing material from the beating. The pastor who publicly humiliates the member for 'backsliding' gains nothing material. The mob who kills the 'blasphemer' gains nothing material. The right to enforce feels natural, automatic, and legitimate.

The believer who reports the atheist colleague to the employer gains nothing material. The Imam who orders the congregant to leave the interfaith marriage gains nothing material. The youth leader who pressures the youth member to denounce their LGBTQ+ sibling gains nothing material. Each is exercising internalised authority — the felt right to enforce the religious standard regardless of personal gain.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the religious subject, the religious minority, and the doubter. The subject is taught that they cannot question the religion. The minority is taught that they must accept second-class status. The doubter is taught that their doubt is a personal failing. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The Catholic woman who is told by her priest 'the Church does not ordain women' is being disciplined by Canon. The Shia Muslim who is told by the Sunni neighbour 'you are not really Muslim' is being disciplined by Canon. The atheist who is told by the family 'you are going to hell' is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

The deepest form of this is the adherent who has absorbed Religious Dominance so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The doubter who says 'I should pray more' to silence their questions. The convert who says 'I have betrayed my community' and returns to the original religion. The religious minority who says 'it is our place to be quiet' to explain why they do not protest discrimination. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The religious enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The religious subject forgets they can rebel. The religious witness forgets they can dissent. The middle-aged parent who has been both subject and enforcer forgets they were ever either.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body. Saba Mahmood, in *Politics of Piety* (2005), extended Bourdieu's analysis to show how pious practice produces the pious subject: the woman who wears the hijab, prays five times daily, and fasts Ramadan does not experience these as external demands but as the structure of her own agency. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

By the time the Nigerian child is twelve, the religious practice is reflex. The Muslim child does not decide to pray. The body prays. The Christian child does not decide to attend Sunday school. The body attends. By adulthood, the adherent has performed the religious identity, practice, purity, authority, and law triads so many thousands of times that the alternative — questioning, leaving, refusing — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Religious Dominance is spectacular: the Boko Haram massacres in Baga, Bama, and Borno villages from 2009 to the present, with thousands killed in the name of establishing an Islamic state. The religious riots — Miss World 2002 in Kaduna (over 200 killed), the 2006 cartoon riots across northern Nigeria (over 100 killed), the 2011 post-election violence in Kaduna and Zaria (over 800 killed).

The Deborah Samuel lynching of May 2022 in Sokoto. The Bridget Agbahome killing of June 2016 in Kano. The Mubarak Bala sentencing of April 2022 to 24 years' imprisonment for blasphemy. The sectarian killings in Plateau State — Jos 2001 (over 1,000 killed), Jos 2008 (over 700 killed), Jos 2010 (over 500 killed). The Shia IMN procession killings in Zaria, December 2015 (over 300 killed by the military). The targeted killings of clergy — Catholic priests kidnapped and killed in the North, Pentecostal pastors murdered in the Middle Belt.

Slow death in Religious Dominance is quiet. Chronic stress from constant religious conformity — the adherent who has not missed a prayer in twenty years and whose body cannot rest. Mental health collapse from religious trauma — the child raised on fear of hell who reaches adulthood with chronic anxiety, sleep disorders, and a relationship to their own body shaped by terror.

LGBTQ+ Nigerians driven to breakdown or suicide by religious condemnation — the gay man who hears his identity described as abomination from the pulpit every Sunday, the lesbian who is told by her pastor she is possessed, the trans Nigerian who is told by their Imam they are cursed. The doubter who cannot leave without losing community — the atheist who has to perform belief to keep their family, their job, their safety.

The woman ground down by religious gender role enforcement — the wife whose pastor tells her to 'submit' to the abusive husband, the daughter whose Imam tells her the father's word is divine command. The religious trauma syndrome documented by psychologists — the symptom cluster of

anxiety, depression, dissociation, and somatic complaints found in patients who have left high-control religious communities. None of these make the news. They are Religious Dominance's quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Religious Dominance produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The groups are religious minorities, atheists, apostates, LGBTQ+ Nigerians (because religious authority is the primary source of anti-LGBTQ+ violence), doubters, and women in conservative religious communities. The premature death is fast (Boko Haram, religious riots, blasphemy killings, sectarian massacres) or slow (stress, trauma, breakdown, internal exile). Every ascended matrix kills. Religious Dominance kills those whose faith does not fit.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Religious Dominance Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Religious Dominance rewrite history in popular Nigerian living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Religious Dominance was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian religion was syncretic and flexible. The Yoruba Orisa tradition, the Igbo Agbara/Alusi system, the Hausa Maguzawa, the Tiv Akombo, the Efikan Ndem, and dozens of other systems had no missionaries, no canon, no centralised authority. An individual could consult multiple deities, change their primary spiritual allegiance, and participate in festivals across traditions without category crisis. Conversion was not a category.

Islam arrived in West Africa through trans-Saharan trade from the 11th century, but the Sokoto Jihad of 1804 was a recent political-theological event. The Jihad imposed a stricter Islamic identity on the Hausa states and displaced the syncretic Hausa Islam that had existed alongside Maguzawa traditionalists. Christianity arrived with the colonial missions in the 1840s and was imposed through the school system. Both religions arrived as invasions of older arrangements.

Colonial codification (1900-1960) made religious identity an administrative category. The colonial state treated the North as Muslim and the South as Christian for administrative convenience, freezing a more fluid pre-colonial reality. Indirect Rule in the North used the Emirate structure as the administrative unit, with the Emir as both political and religious authority. Missionary activity in the South used the school as the primary conversion instrument, with education and conversion effectively fused.

Post-independence replication continued the displacement. The 1979 Constitution's 'multi-religious state' framing codified the colonial settlement. The 1987 OIC membership controversy (Nigeria joining the Organisation of Islamic Conference) and the 1999-2002 Sharia implementation debate were continuations, not innovations. The CAN/SCIA divide as the primary religious-identity structure of public life was the colonial settlement matured.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1960**. For Nigerians born after 1940 — the independence generation and after — Religious Dominance has 'always been' in its current form. They cannot recall a time when religious identity was not a primary social category. The pre-colonial syncretic generation (born ~1870s-1890s) was the last to have living memory of flexible religious identity. By independence (1960), that generation had been displaced from policy-making by the colonial-trained elite, and the colonial religious settlement had become the natural order.

What changed in that moment? Two things. First, the colonial codification of religious identity as administrative category became the post-colonial default, so that the first generation to grow up entirely inside the new structure reached adulthood in the 1950s and 1960s. Second, the post-independence religious institutions (CAN 1976, SCIA 1973) consolidated the colonial settlement into the formal bloc structure that now organises Nigerian public life. By 1960, the question ‘is religious identity natural?’ had stopped being asked in popular memory.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Religious Dominance in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around someone whose faith does not fit — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Religious Dominance rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person who first made you feel that challenging them was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The religious performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The religious identity or category at the centre of the moment was: _____.

Question 2: How is Religious Dominance causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Religious Dominance is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress from years of compulsory religious conformity; the insomnia from years of swallowing questions I wanted to ask my religious leader; the loss of self from years of being told my doubt is sin; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the relationship I lost because I could not stop performing piety at home; the medical diagnosis I now live with because the stress had nowhere else to go; the internal exile I am in because my faith cannot be spoken; the religious trauma syndrome that surfaces every time I enter a place of worship.) The matrix’s name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Religious Dominance. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the religious leader demands, the next time the congregant performs, the next time the unbeliever is silenced — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the enforcer in the triad, the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 7 will take up Enclosure — the system that privatises access to resources required for living (originally land, extended to housing, water, healthcare, food systems, knowledge, data, and any other material or condition required for the subject’s current living conditions). Enclosure overlaps with Religious Dominance at the point of religious property (Chapter 6) and with Cisheteropatriarchy at the point of marital property (Chapter 5). The framework separates it so that the privatisation logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 8 is Productivism, Chapter 9 is Invasion, Chapter 10 is Settler Colonialism, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2 through 6. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.